

telling us that we need more and more to be happy, and if we make goals out of arbitrary amounts of money or certain material possessions, it will never seem enough by the time we get there. So, how do we change the way that we view money, after a lifetime of being told that the ultimate goal can be quantified in the form of a certain salary or amassed wealth?

In my experience, the only thing that works is to shift our focus from monetary amounts to life situations, and then work backwards to figure out how much money we need to earn, save or invest to achieve that lifestyle. When we spoke, Anna Codrea-Rado framed this as 'lifestyle design', something that she says isn't taught to us early enough in life – and I agree. For those of us who are not independently wealthy, if we want to achieve a sense of financial wellbeing, it's absolutely essential for our earning potential in our jobs and our plans for our lifestyle to complement one another. In fact, according to Mo Gawdat's happiness equation, it's more or less vital for general happiness. The formula for happiness that he proposes in international bestseller *Solve for Happy* is that your happiness is equal to or greater than your perception of the events in your life minus your expectations of how life should behave. Positioned by Gawdat as an alternative to the complex and unending musings on human happiness by philosophers and psychologists, this simple equation is something that we can pull ourselves back to every time we can't work out why we don't yet feel satisfied with our lives. I'm always sceptical about anything that claims to reduce